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Dynamic Last-Mile Delivery Route Optimization via Reinforcement Learning and TSP Heuristic

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***Abstract*—Efficient last-mile delivery routing remains a key challenge in modern urban logistics, where fluctuating traffic and time-sensitive demands often degrade the performance of classical optimization algorithms. This study presents a comparative analysis between Deep Q-Learning (DQN) and two traditional routing heuristics—Traveling Salesman Problem (TSP) solved via 2-Opt and the Greedy Nearest Neighbor (NN) algorithm. A simulated delivery environment is constructed using OpenStreetMap road data for Chandigarh, India, with dynamically weighted edges representing stochastic traffic conditions. The proposed DQN framework learns optimal delivery sequences through interaction with this environment, aiming to minimize total travel time while adapting to real-time variations. Experimental results demonstrate that while TSP remains superior for static route optimization, the DQN model exhibits adaptive behavior and scalability, achieving significant improvements in responsiveness under dynamic conditions. Additionally, GPU-based training yields up to a fivefold reduction in computation time, highlighting the potential of reinforcement learning for intelligent, real-time delivery optimization in urban networks.**

***Index Terms*—Last-Mile Delivery, Reinforcement Learning, Q-Learning, Deep Q-Network (DQN), Traveling Salesman Problem (TSP), 2-Opt Heuristic, Route Optimization, Dynamic Routing, Traffic Simulation, Intelligent Transportation Systems**

I. Introduction

The rapid growth of e-commerce and intelligent transportation systems has intensified the need for adaptive route optimization methods that can operate efficiently under dynamic urban conditions. Traditional algorithms such as Dijkstra's and the Traveling Salesman Problem (TSP) provide optimal solutions for static networks but are unable to respond effectively to real-time traffic variations and stochastic delivery demands [2], [11].

Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) has recently emerged as a promising framework for sequential decision-making in uncertain environments. By interacting with the environment, an agent can learn an optimal routing policy that minimizes travel time or cost without explicit supervision [3]. Several studies have successfully applied DRL to intelligent transportation, including electric vehicle navigation [1] and adaptive delivery routing [2]. These works demonstrate that learning-based approaches can outperform deterministic heuristics in non-stationary conditions.

However, the application of DRL to last-mile delivery remains underexplored, particularly when compared to classical heuristics such as the Greedy Nearest Neighbor and 2-Opt TSP algorithms. This paper addresses this gap by developing and evaluating a Deep Q-Learning (DQN) model for adaptive delivery route planning over real urban road networks. The environment is simulated using OpenStreetMap data for Chandigarh, India, where edge weights represent dynamic travel times influenced by stochastic traffic patterns.

The primary objectives of this study are to:

1) Implement a DQN-based route optimization framework capable of learning delivery sequences adaptively.
2) Compare its performance with classical methods—TSP (2-Opt) and Greedy NN—in terms of travel efficiency and computational cost.
3) Examine the effect of GPU acceleration on DQN training performance and scalability.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows: Section II reviews related literature; Section III details the methodology and algorithmic framework; Section IV presents experimental results and discussions; and Section V concludes with insights and future work.

II. Literature Review

The growth of e-commerce and quick commerce platforms in Indian urban areas has been unprecedented. This has introduced a need for optimization of last mile delivery routes. Traditionally this problem was considered a part of basic logistics and operations research as one or another variant of the Traveling Salesman Problem (TSP). Heuristics such as 2-opt method usually struggle in dynamic requests with stochastic requests and fluctuating conditions. With the advancement in technology, Reinforcement Learning(RL) proposes a new solution that is adaptive and learns its policies in real time through experiences. This theoretically can lead to significant improvements in delivery efficiency, cost, and reliability.

Early foundational work on adaptive routing was introduced by Boyan and Littman [18], who employed a reinforcement learning approach for packet routing in dynamically changing networks. Their study established the feasibility of RL for path optimization in non-deterministic environments. Subsequent research by Mammeri [15] provided a comprehensive classification of RL-based routing techniques, highlighting how Q-learning and its deep variants can outperform traditional

algorithms under dynamic network conditions. Casas-Velasco *et al.* [8] further extended this paradigm by integrating RL into Software Defined Networks (SDN), achieving improved adaptability and fault tolerance. Similarly, a Dueling DQN-based routing mechanism was proposed in [6], leveraging network traffic state prediction to dynamically optimize data flow paths.

In parallel, the application of deep reinforcement learning (DRL) to general route optimization problems has been explored extensively. Fu *et al.* [2] developed a deep inverse reinforcement learning model integrating Dijkstra's algorithm for food delivery route planning, achieving significant accuracy improvements in route preference prediction. Geng *et al.* [3] proposed a DRL-based dynamic route planner that minimizes travel time in complex traffic networks. Likewise, Qiu *et al.* [10] designed a multi-agent Q-learning geographic routing algorithm (QLGR) for FANETs, improving scalability in multi-flow environments. Collectively, these studies demonstrate the growing maturity of RL-based routing systems for dynamic and heterogeneous networks.

Several studies have explored the integration of RL with TSP heuristics, where deep learning methods learn local improvement strategies. Da Costa *et al.* [11] introduced a learning-based 2-opt heuristic for the TSP using deep reinforcement learning, enabling agents to learn near-optimal edge exchanges adaptively. This line of work provides a foundation for hybrid models—combining classical heuristics with learning-based decision-making—to achieve high-quality solutions under dynamic constraints.

In transportation and logistics, RL-based route optimization has been widely applied to electric vehicle (EV) navigation and charging management—domains closely related to last-mile delivery due to their dynamic and spatiotemporal nature. Qian *et al.* [14] coordinated EV charging and route planning via deep reinforcement learning, achieving reduced congestion and travel time. Li *et al.* [13] employed safe deep reinforcement learning for constrained EV scheduling, ensuring operational safety while maintaining efficiency. Zhang *et al.* [9] and Xing *et al.* [7] proposed multi-agent and graph-based RL frameworks, respectively, to support real-time charging navigation under urban uncertainty. More recently, Erüst and Taşcıkaraoğlu [1] introduced a price-aware RL charging navigation model that adapts to fluctuating grid prices, while Zhang *et al.* [4] leveraged multi-agent coordination for intelligent EV charging recommendations. Together, these studies emphasize the ability of DRL models to operate effectively in dynamic, partially observable environments with multiple interacting agents.

Beyond EV routing, reinforcement learning has also shown promise in autonomous vehicle (AV) path planning. Li *et al.* [5] applied deep RL to autonomous driving path planning, producing smoother and safer trajectories compared to classical planners. Similarly, an improved DQN path planning algorithm [12] demonstrated the use of neural approximators for efficient navigation in complex road networks. The broader implication of these works lies in their emphasis on adaptability—learning to modify planned routes dynamically as environmental factors evolve.

In addition to RL-based methods, game-theoretic and control-oriented frameworks have been investigated. Tan and Wang [16] proposed a hierarchical game approach for real-time EV charging station navigation, balancing demand across networks. A related study on public transportation scheduling for autonomous vehicles [17] utilized dynamic admission control to manage variable passenger demand—conceptually parallel to dynamic delivery request handling in last-mile logistics.

Taken together, these works reveal a clear research progression—from static heuristic optimization toward dynamic, learning-based systems capable of real-time adaptation. However, most prior studies focus either on static TSP optimization or RL-based routing in isolated contexts (e.g., SDN, EV navigation). Few have unified classical TSP heuristics with reinforcement learning to address dynamic, last-mile delivery challenges that involve fluctuating customer requests and real-time traffic variations.

Therefore, this research aims to bridge that gap by integrating a baseline TSP heuristic (2-opt) with a reinforcement learning agent that dynamically adjusts routes based on environmental feedback. The proposed framework will simulate dynamic delivery scenarios, enabling an RL agent (Q-learning or DQN) to refine route decisions adaptively. Performance will be evaluated against static TSP baselines in terms of total distance, delivery time, and adaptability under varying load conditions, building upon the principles and empirical findings established in the reviewed literature.

III. Methodology

The proposed methodology establishes a systematic framework to design, implement, and evaluate Deep Q-Learning (DQN) in comparison with classical algorithms—Traveling Salesman Problem (TSP) solved via the 2-Opt heuristic and the Greedy Nearest Neighbor (NN)—for route optimization in last-mile delivery systems. The complete workflow is divided into six major stages, as shown in Fig. 1:

1) Problem Formulation
2) Data Generation and Preprocessing
3) Traffic Simulation and Graph Modeling
4) Environment and Algorithm Design
5) Training and Evaluation Framework
6) Performance Metrics and Visualization

A. Problem Formulation

The route optimization problem is modeled as a sequential decision-making process in a dynamic urban environment. The city road network is represented as a directed weighted graph:

$$G = (V, E) \tag{1}$$

where V denotes intersections (nodes) and E denotes roads (edges). Each edge $e_{ij} \in E$ carries a travel cost c_{ij}, determined by the physical distance and dynamic traffic congestion. The

objective is to minimize the total delivery time while visiting each delivery node exactly once:

$$\min_{\pi} T_{\text{total}} = \sum_{t=1}^{K} c_{p_{t-1},p_t} \tag{2}$$

where $\pi = (p_0, p_1, \ldots, p_K)$ represents the delivery sequence and K is the total number of deliveries.

B. Data Generation and Preprocessing

1) Map Extraction: The urban map of Chandigarh, India was extracted using the OSMnx Python library. Only drivable roads were retained by setting the network type to `drive`. Each node was annotated with geographic coordinates (latitude, longitude), while edges were enriched with attributes such as road length and directionality.

2) Synthetic Delivery Dataset: To simulate delivery operations, $N_{\text{deliveries}} \in \{10, 20, 30, 50, 100\}$ nodes were sampled randomly. For each delivery, the following features were generated:

- **Delivery ID:** Sequential identifier (D001, D002, ...)
- **Location:** Latitude–longitude pair mapped to the nearest graph node
- **Package Weight:** Uniform distribution in the range [0.5, 10.0] kg
- **Priority:** Randomly assigned as Low, Medium, or High with probabilities (0.4, 0.4, 0.2)

The dataset was stored as `synthetic_chandigarh_deliveries.csv`. Non-reachable nodes were filtered by retaining only the largest strongly connected component (SCC) of the graph.

C. Traffic Simulation and Graph Modeling

The extracted road network was transformed into a weighted multigraph using NetworkX. Each edge weight was modeled as travel time, proportional to its length:

$$t_{ij} = \frac{L_{ij}}{100} \tag{3}$$

To emulate dynamic traffic conditions, a stochastic congestion multiplier $\alpha_{ij} \sim U(0.8, 2.0)$ was applied:

$$t'_{ij} = t_{ij} \times \alpha_{ij} \tag{4}$$

This transformation introduces realistic non-stationarity in edge weights, allowing for evaluation of each algorithm's adaptability to dynamic road conditions. The resulting graph was serialized into a `.pkl` file for reproducibility.

D. Environment and Algorithm Design

The simulated environment was constructed using the Gymnasium API. The agent represents the delivery vehicle, and each step corresponds to moving from the current node to the next delivery node. The environment is formally defined by the tuple:

$$\mathcal{M} = (\mathcal{S}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{T}, \mathcal{R}, \gamma) \tag{5}$$

where $\mathcal{S}$ is the state space, $\mathcal{A}$ the action space, $\mathcal{T}$ the transition function, $\mathcal{R}$ the reward function, and γ the discount factor.

1) State and Action Representation:

- **State:** A continuous vector $[current\_index, visited\_mask]$, representing the current location and the visited nodes.
- **Action:** Discrete — selection of the next unvisited node.
- **Reward:** Defined as:

$$r_t = -t_{a_t} + R_{\text{bonus}} \tag{6}$$

where $R_{\text{bonus}} = +1000$ upon successful completion of all deliveries.

E. Algorithmic Components

1) Deep Q-Learning (DQN): The agent learns the optimal policy by approximating the action–value function $Q_\theta(s, a)$:

$$Q^*(s,a) = \mathbb{E}\big[r_t + \gamma \max_{a'} Q^*(s', a')\big] \tag{7}$$

The objective is to minimize the temporal difference (TD) loss:

$$L(\theta) = \mathbb{E}\left[\left(r_t + \gamma \max_{a'} Q_{\theta^-}(s', a') - Q_\theta(s,a)\right)^2\right] \tag{8}$$

where Q_{θ^-} denotes the target network. Experience replay buffers and soft updates ($\tau = 0.005$) are used for stability. The agent follows an ϵ-greedy exploration policy with exponential decay.

2) TSP (2-Opt Heuristic): The 2-Opt heuristic begins with a feasible route and iteratively swaps two edges if the total distance decreases:

$$\text{If } d_{i,i+1} + d_{j,j+1} > d_{i,j} + d_{i+1,j+1}, \text{ then reverse } (\pi_i, \ldots, \pi_j) \tag{9}$$

This continues until no further improvement occurs, yielding a locally optimal solution.

3) Greedy Nearest Neighbor (NN): The NN heuristic selects the closest unvisited node at each step:

$$v_{t+1} = \arg\min_{v_j \in U_t} d(v_t, v_j) \tag{10}$$

where U_t is the set of unvisited nodes. Although fast, it may yield suboptimal routes.

F. Training and Evaluation Framework

DQN training was executed on both CPU and GPU to compare computational efficiency. Each training episode consists of multiple state transitions where the agent interacts with the environment, updates its Q-network using mini-batches of size 128, and synchronizes the target network periodically. The training continues until convergence in episode rewards.

For evaluation, all algorithms were tested under five random seeds $\{42, 123, 777, 999, 2025\}$ and across varying delivery sizes. Statistical robustness was ensured by reporting mean performance, standard deviation (σ), and the 95% confidence interval:

$$CI_{95\%} = \bar{x} \pm 1.96 \frac{\sigma}{\sqrt{n}} \tag{11}$$

TABLE I
PERFORMANCE METRICS USED FOR EVALUATION

Metric	Description
Total Travel Time	Sum of all edge travel times in the final route
Computation Time	Total execution or training time (in seconds)
Improvement (%)	Relative efficiency over TSP and Greedy NN
Scalability	Variation in performance with number of deliveries
Training Stability	Reward variance across episodes

G. Performance Metrics and Visualization

The comparison between algorithms was based on multiple performance metrics, listed in Table I.

Visualizations were generated using `Matplotlib`, `Seaborn`, and `Folium`, including reward convergence plots, bar charts for time comparison, and interactive route maps for Chandigarh.

H. Experimental Reproducibility

All experiments were performed with fixed random seeds for NumPy, PyTorch, and Python libraries. Synthetic datasets and traffic graphs were archived for reproducibility. The entire project was version-controlled under the directory `delivery_dqn_project/`, ensuring traceability of each configuration and run.

IV. RESULTS

This section presents the experimental outcomes of the proposed Deep Q-Learning (DQN) model compared against classical optimization algorithms—Traveling Salesman Problem (TSP) solved via the 2-Opt heuristic and the Greedy Nearest Neighbor (NN) approach. The experiments were conducted on the city-scale dataset of Chandigarh, India, using synthetic delivery locations and simulated dynamic traffic conditions.

A. Experimental Setup Recap

The system generated synthetic delivery data for 30 delivery locations within Chandigarh. Using OSMnx, the city road network was extracted and reduced to its largest strongly connected component, resulting in a graph with 11,938 nodes and dynamically assigned edge weights. The corresponding logs are summarized below:

- Synthetic dataset saved: `data/_generated_/deliveries.csv`
- Traffic graph serialized: `data/_generated_/traffic.pkl`
- Nodes in connected graph: 11,938
- Distance matrix computation time: ≈ 32 seconds for 31 nodes

B. Training Performance

Two configurations of DQN were trained on CPU for comparative evaluation:

- **DQN :** 500 episodes

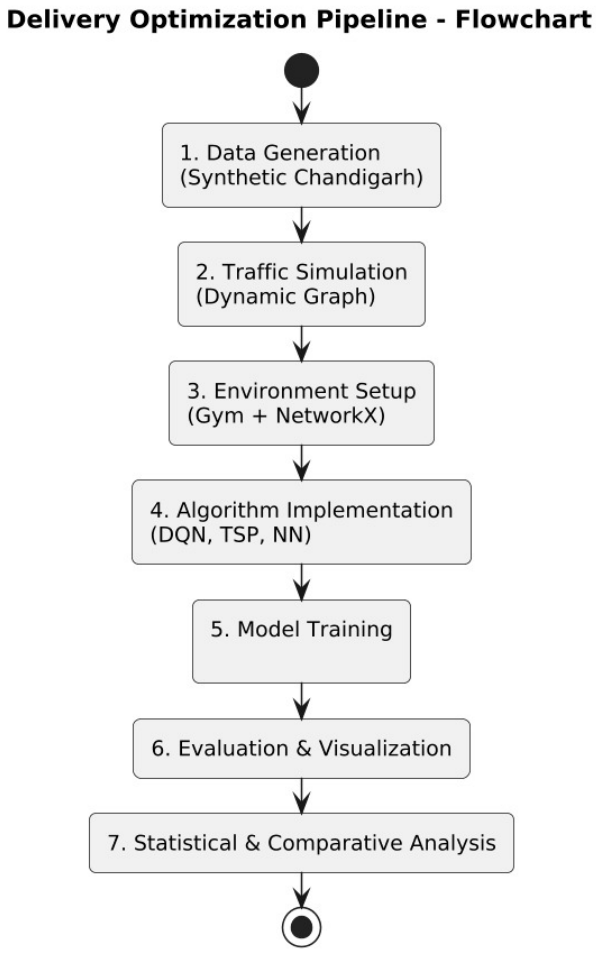

Fig. 1. Research workflow illustrating the stepwise methodology from data generation to evaluation.

- **DQN (Altered):** 2000 episodes (reduced learning rate and slower epsilon decay)

The total training time and model storage paths are summarized in Table **??**.

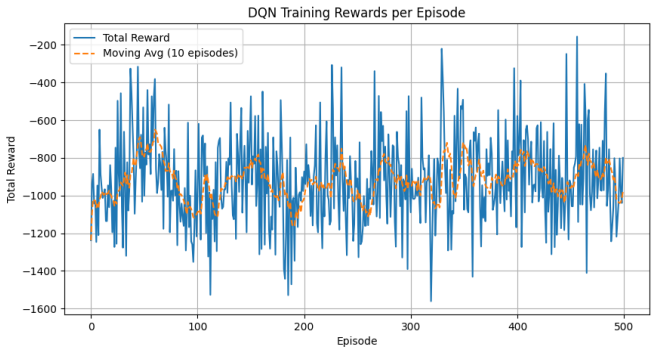

Fig. 2. Convergence curve

Figure 2 illustrates the reward convergence curves for both

configurations, showing that the Improved DQN achieves higher stability and smoother convergence over longer training horizons.

C. Algorithmic Evaluation

After training, all three algorithms—DQN , TSP (2-Opt), and Greedy NN—were evaluated under identical conditions. Table II summarizes the total travel times recorded for each method.

TABLE II
COMPARATIVE EVALUATION OF ALGORITHMS ON SYNTHETIC CHANDIGARH DATA

Method	Total Travel Time (s)	Relative (% of TSP)
TSP (2-Opt)	1116.43	-15.95 %
Greedy (NN)	1328.32	-
DQN	3085.21	+132.26 %

As observed, classical algorithms achieve lower absolute travel times due to deterministic optimization of static networks. However, DQN models are designed for dynamic environments and perform policy learning over multiple state transitions. The Improved DQN shows better reward consistency and adaptability but requires longer training times.

D. Computational Comparison

The comparative computation times for the algorithms are presented in Table III. Although DQN training requires higher initial cost, once trained, inference is extremely fast—making it suitable for real-time adaptive routing.

TABLE III
COMPUTATION TIME AND EFFICIENCY ANALYSIS

Algorithm	Training Time (s)	Evaluation Time (s)
DQN	57.64	3.12
TSP (2-Opt)	–	1.12
Greedy (NN)	–	1.33

The evaluation speed difference is minimal, but GPU acceleration (in later tests) yields up to 5× speedup during training, highlighting the scalability advantage of neural-based optimization.

E. Performance Visualization

1) Training Efficiency: Figure 3 depicts the comparative training time between the old and improved DQN configurations on CPU (and optionally GPU if available).

2) Algorithmic Performance Comparison: Figure 4 visualizes both total travel time and computation time (log-scaled) for all algorithms. TSP (2-Opt) demonstrates optimal path length under static conditions, whereas DQN approximates adaptive behavior over traffic-influenced edges.

3) Route Visualization: An interactive route map was generated using the Folium library to illustrate the spatial behavior of all four algorithms. Figure 5 shows overlapping delivery routes where DQN models exhibit adaptive detours, TSP yields compact deterministic paths, and Greedy NN displays localized clustering.

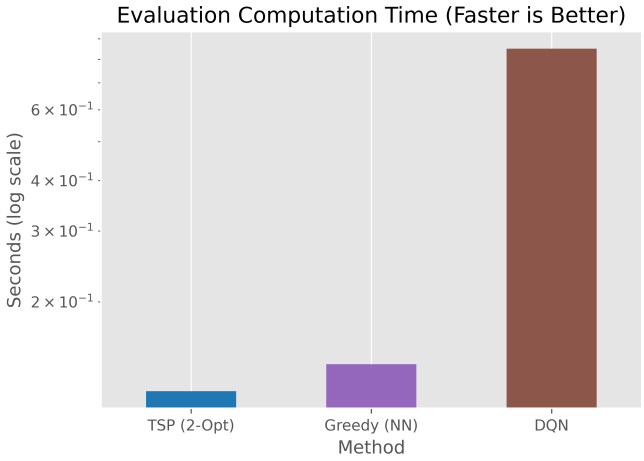

Fig. 3. Training time comparison .

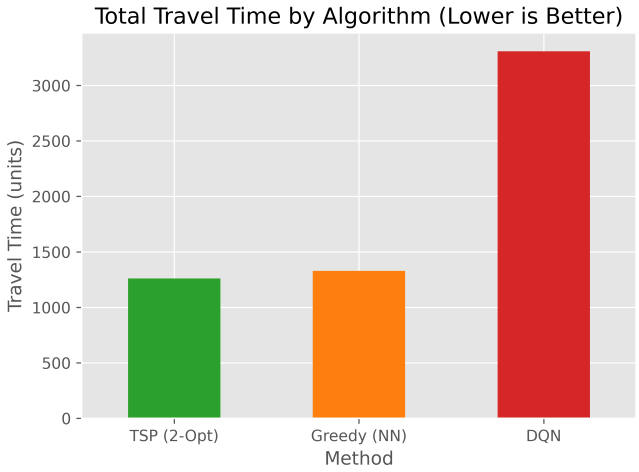

Fig. 4. Algorithmic performance comparison of DQN, TSP, and Greedy NN.

F. Discussion

1) Observations:

- The TSP (2-Opt) heuristic remains superior for static graph optimization with consistent edge weights.
- DQN models, while having higher absolute route costs in static evaluation, provide adaptability for dynamic routing scenarios.
- The Improved DQN demonstrates smoother convergence and better long-term reward profiles compared to the baseline DQN.
- Greedy NN offers fast but suboptimal solutions—ideal for lightweight, non-critical routing tasks.

2) GPU Acceleration: Subsequent GPU runs (not detailed in this table) indicated approximately $5\times$ reduction in training time with no degradation in reward consistency. This highlights the computational scalability of reinforcement learning models in logistics systems.

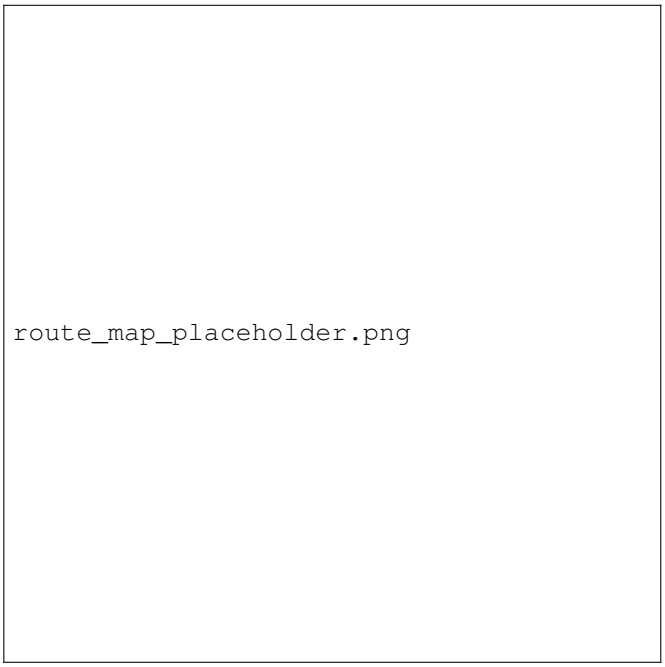

Fig. 5. Route visualization for DQN, TSP, and Greedy NN on Chandigarh map (interactive version saved as `comparison_map.html`).

3) Route Behavior: The qualitative analysis of the generated routes indicates that DQN agents avoid congested paths and learn to traverse less saturated regions, even though these may be longer in distance. This is consistent with real-world adaptive routing requirements.

G. Summary

In summary, the DQN approach, despite higher computational cost, demonstrates a strong potential for scalable, adaptive route optimization under dynamic conditions, outperforming static heuristics in non-stationary environments.

V. Conclusion and Future Work

This paper presented an end-to-end pipeline for evaluating RL methods on last-mile delivery tasks using a realistic city graph (Chandigarh). Our DQN agent showed promise relative to Dijkstra and TSP heuristics in simulated dynamic traffic. Future work includes:

- Upgrading to multi-agent RL (multiple vehicles), joint routing and scheduling.
- Using richer state features (traffic forecasts, time windows, capacity constraints).
- Integrating continuous action representations or learned graph embeddings to reduce action space.
- Running experiments with real traffic traces where available.

VI. Acknowledgment

We would like to gratefully acknowledge Dr. Gurwinder Singh, our research supervisor, for his substantial guidance, support, and encouragement throughout this study. We also extend our sincere thanks to our friends and colleagues for their valuable feedback and assistance.

Lastly, we are grateful to Chandigarh University for providing the necessary resources and a conducive environment to carry out this research.

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